

Post-incident review PIR-2026-023

Notification Service: stale data shown to users

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 19 July 2026, Notification Service experienced stale data shown to users in production (AU East) for about 240 minutes. A latency threshold alert fired for the service's main endpoint. Investigation found that a pipeline overwrote the environment variable that pointed the service at its cache cluster.

Impact

Users of Notification Service saw stale data shown to users for about 240 minutes. The service owner, Messaging, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:05 First signal received.
- 09:34 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:57 Likely cause identified.
- 10:23 Mitigation applied.
- 10:32 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a pipeline overwrote the environment variable that pointed the service at its cache cluster.

Customer impact was limited because most traffic was served from cache.

It took time to work out which team owned the affected component.

There was no documented procedure for this failure mode, so responders worked it out live.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.
- Add a pre-deployment check that validates the setting against the production baseline.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.